

This project expands on the concepts from Project Three, adding the element of reactivity to sound to marry the ideas of transience and transformation. Although this project didn't turn out exactly as I had imagined when I initially began development, I allowed my own constraints and the constraints of the development environment to guide the composition's evolution. This led to a piece which in essence captures the idea of words transforming based on their environment.

Throughout this semester, I often found myself questioning the purpose of using words when the words themselves took a backseat to the medium by which they were manipulated. However, after reading *Beyond Taxonomy: Digital Poetics and Programmed Significance* by Talan Meemmot in "New Media Poetics," I understood that digital poetry and the medium used to create it are two halves of one whole. Where the experience is embedded in the marrying of many facets (like sound, visuals, and words). This led to a series of thought processes by which I understood that words should not be used for the explicit purpose of reading, rather they should elicit something deeper through their manipulation in the program.

Taking this new understanding, I wanted to look beyond using words as solely a means to be read; I wanted to find a way to manipulate them so that they would evoke emotion through their transformation. Pulling from my Project Three concept of ephemeral states, I wanted sound to be the heartbeat of this project. To me, nothing cements the concepts of temporality and nomadism better than sound because it travels and dissipates with only a memory of its existence remaining. This project highlights this fact by using sound to manipulate a static text where the text only becomes more legible through sound while simultaneously becoming illegible as it breaks into particles, eventually coming together again and retaining its original form.

The purpose of this manipulation became even more clear when I realized that the particles would form new and random shapes regardless of the sound of the word being said at that moment. One word yielded a different result and I began to connect this concept to meaning itself, where the same word holds different weight depending on its use. It also captured this idea that the words on the screen (now a cacophony of particles) are meaningless, relying only on their shape to evoke emotion as opposed to the content itself. By relying on the paratext, I found that a program that was seemingless on the surface became an experience that called for the viewer to look for their own meaning.

I also found that my own technological inabilities yielded interesting results when it came to the sound manipulation itself. I had originally intended for the program to react to all sound in a uniform way, where each word had equal weight in deforming the background and the particle structure; however, I had learned that the particles were working off the snare capture and the background was working off of the kick and mid structures. At first I found myself working tirelessly to fix this, but sooner found that this became an interesting dichotomy when working with speech and music. Regular speech felt more impactful because the background vibrated with the words and the particles would only react to certain inflections. Music, however, moved the particles in such a way that the rhythm became a force of its own. I sooner began to appreciate that I had no idea how to fix this problem because it became a way for me to consider how differently the two mediums cohabitate with words.

This project exposed me to the true meaning of digital poetry. Strict classifications are meaningless in a genre that demands an appreciation for technological capacity at every step of its evolutionary process. Through this composition, I also found myself building a more complex understand of digital poetry and its infinite possibilities.

References

Talan Meemmot, 2006. "Beyond Taxonomy: Digital Poetics and Programmed Significance",
New Media Poetics: **Contexts, Technotexts, and Theories**, Adalaide Morris, Thomas
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